Learning Story 6: ‘It Goes Fast Here’

Stacey and Hank sat together in the outdoor learning space, their attention drawn to a simple setup, a plank resting on a low crate, forming a ramp. A container of water and a collection of cups and loose parts sat nearby. Emma, their educator, watched closely, noticing the “bright centre” of their learning beginning to form. Stacey carefully poured water from a cup onto the top of the ramp and exclaimed, “Look, it’s going fast.” Hank crouched down, following the stream with his finger. “It goes fast here” he said while pointing to the top of the ramp. They were playfully exploring science ideas and wondering “how does water flow?”, noticing speed, direction, and water movement.

Emma leaned into the children’s play gently and with shared interest saying, “I wonder what makes the water move faster or slower?” Hank stopped for a moment, looking around and then he stood up and grabbed another plank. “This one is longer” he said, placing it beside the first. Without prompting, their exploration expanded outward, like the soft halo around a torch beam into mathematical thinking as they compared length and height.

Emma fostered their thinking by asking, “Which ramp do you think will make the water go fastest?” Then with a construction approach the focus of their learning beam extended into engineering thinking as the children began adjusting their ramps, experimenting with crates and blocks. Hank stacked two crates while saying “It needs to be higher to go faster.” Emma guided their process with intention and made a STEM connection for the children. She commented, “you’re changing your design to see what works best. That’s what engineers do.”

Noticing the children’s joy and engagement with the STEM experience, Emma introduced the classroom iPad and asked, “Would you like to record what your water does?” With help from Emma, Stacey took the iPad, filming as Hank poured water. “Now we can watch it again!” she said. Together with Emma guiding their use of the iPad, they replayed the video, comparing different ramp designs.








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